

YOUR OWN MONEY. YOUR OWN EVERYTHING.

the money map.

three pages, plain language. what should be in your name, where each dollar goes, and the tax stuff nobody explained. start anywhere. done beats perfect.

five things that should be yours.

check them off one at a time, smallest first. if you're doing well, run it as an audit — most people find one thing they assumed was covered.

1

an account that's yours alone

the single most important line. money you can reach without asking anyone.

DO THIS

open a checking or savings account in your name only, at a bank you picked. have part of every paycheck land there.

2

credit in your own name

a score that's actually yours — not borrowed from someone else's card.

DO THIS

be the primary holder on at least one card. set autopay for the full statement balance. check your reports free at annualcreditreport.com.

3

access to the paperwork

where it all lives, and how to get to it in an afternoon.

DO THIS

one folder, paper + digital: ID, passport, social security card, birth certificate, tax returns, lease or deed, insurance, and every account login.

4

a cushion that's yours

what lets you handle a surprise — or leave — without asking anyone.

DO THIS

build it in stages (below) in a high-yield savings account in your name. same FDIC insurance as a big bank, more interest.

5

one number you know

what comes in, what goes out, what you're worth — so nothing blindsides you.

DO THIS

write down monthly take-home, monthly essentials, and net worth (what you own minus what you owe). check it once a month.

THE CUSHION, IN STAGES — EACH ONE IS A REAL WIN

STAGE 1

\$500

proof you can save. covers a deductible or a vet visit.

STAGE 2

\$1,000

most one-off emergencies land under this.

STAGE 3

1 month

of essentials — rent, food, bills, insurance.

STAGE 4

3–6 mo.

more if self-employed or a single parent.

THE SPLIT

give every dollar a job before it disappears.

two splits: one for every paycheck, one for money that shows up extra.
they're starting points — bend them to your life, but bend **joy** first, never **future-you**.

EVERY PAYCHECK

50%

now

rent, food, bills, insurance

30%

future-you

cushion, debt, investing

20%

joy

fun, travel, treats

EXTRA MONEY — BONUS, REFUND, GIFT, INHERITANCE

50%

future-you

debt, safety, investing

30%

a real goal

a trip, a course, a move

20%

guilt-free fun

yes, really

a \$3,000
take-home month

now

\$1.500

future-you

\$900

joy

\$600

THE ORDER OF OPERATIONS

1 · ON PAYDAY

move **future-you** money **first**, automatically, before you can spend it. what's left is yours to use.

2 · THE CUSHION

fill the \$500 → \$1,000 starter cushion before anything else in future-you.

3 · THE FIRE

pay down **high-interest debt** (credit cards) next. that interest outruns almost any investment.

4 · THE GROWTH

then **invest**: grab any employer 401(k) match, then a Roth IRA. finish the full cushion alongside.

a windfall plays by different rules. park it in a high-yield savings account first and give yourself 30 days before deciding anything. then kill high-interest debt, then divide the rest with the "extra money" split. the biggest windfall mistakes happen in the first week.

YOUR SPLIT

fill it in. one number each.

\$

now

\$

future-you

\$

joy

+ THE KIDS & TAXES LAYER

raising kids? you're probably leaving money on the table.

the credits, the filing status, and the paperwork that protects them. figures are for the 2026 tax year — they change, so check the current year at irs.gov before you file.

FILING STATUS

head of household

the status single parents miss most. if you're unmarried and pay more than half the costs of a home for your child, it means a **bigger standard deduction and better brackets** than filing single.

CHILD TAX CREDIT

\$2,200

per child under 17, now permanent. up to **\$1,700 is refundable** — you can get it even if you owe nothing. the year a child turns 17 it drops to a **\$500** credit for other dependents (which can also cover a parent you support).

DEPENDENT CARE FSA

\$7,500

per household, through your employer, paid with pre-tax dollars — up from \$5,000, the first increase since 1986.

CHILD & DEPENDENT CARE CREDIT

up to 50%

of up to \$3,000 in care costs for one child (\$6,000 for two+) at the lowest incomes. it's **non-refundable** — it only helps if you owe tax.

don't double-dip.

the FSA and the childcare credit cover the **same expense** — you can't claim one dollar of daycare twice. the child tax credit is separate and stacks on top of either.

THE SINGLE-PARENT MUST-DOS

- ☐ **update your W-4** after a birth, a split, or a status change — so your paycheck withholding matches your real situation.
- ☐ **check every beneficiary** — 401(k), IRA, life insurance. these override your will, and an ex can still be listed.
- ☐ **write a will that names a guardian** for your kids. without one, a court decides.
- ☐ **consider term life insurance** if anyone depends on your income. it's usually cheaper than people expect.
- ☐ **keep custody & support papers** in the paperwork folder from page 1, with copies.
- ☐ **save every childcare receipt** and your provider's tax ID — you'll need both to claim the FSA or the credit.

there's a whole library behind this map.

every word decoded, every big move walked through — free, plain language.

multiplata.com →